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An Artifact Analysis on the Stillsuits and Deathstills Used by the Fremen on Arrakis in Dune 2

My chosen film for this artifact analysis is Dune 2. To date it is my favorite movie for the perfect mix of stunning visuals, powerful music, and gripping plot. The details of the sequel—lent to it by the books—give it a sense of infinite complexity, similar to what you see in the real world. One of the technological artifacts that stood out to me more than any of the others was the use of the Fremen's stillsuits and deathstills. Before we dive into the details of the artifact, the environment of Arrakis and the Fremen people have to be understood. Arrakis, the primary setting for both movies, is a desert planet, a land where water is scarce and sand dunes provide the backdrop for many of my favorite scenes and plotlines. Because of this lack of water, it would go to reason that the living people on Arrakis—the Fremen—would consider water to be highly important. In fact, the Fremen have an immense respect for water; they admonish crying and vomiting, they take care not to waste a single drop when possible, and even go so far to attach the “soul” of a person to their water. The consequences of this are twofold: it creates a society affixed to the reverence of water and pushes much of the technology they create to the creation, preservation, and reclamation of water. In this essay, I want to talk about one such technology: the stillsuit, and its offshoot the deathstill.

The stillsuit is a whole body suit, equipped with watertight fabric, a mask and nasal cannula for water reclamation from the breath, and a liquid storage and extraction from bodily excretions. It is usually shown in the film as a dark suit, looking to be made of rubber and cloth, with boots and gloves to match. It seems to be made over a brown cloth and is usually worn with a long cloth cowl, giving the appearance of a dark patchy ruffled spot. This design was acutely made to blend in with the surroundings of Arrakis, a primarily brown planet due to the

rocks and sand. The biggest use of the stillsuits are for traversing the sand dunes over the planet. With use of the stillsuits, almost all of the water lost by a person, whether it be sweat, breathing, or urination can be reclaimed, allowing the wearer to survive weeks in the harsh conditions.

The other side of the stillsuits is the deathstill, an offshoot of the technology and is used to reclaim water from the bodies of the dead. Since humans are upwards of 70% water, a dead body is a valuable asset. Water can be reclaimed either in the field by using a filtered suction device (usually saved for enemies and creatures) or within a sietch. When a Fremen dies, they are sealed with wax and essentially vacuum sealed, allowing the machine to extract as much water from the person as possible. The use of this water is important and will be covered later. Both of these technologies are offshoots of the same technology - water reclamation from the body, and how that enables the creation of a society based around this resource.

The interesting thing about stillsuits is that every member of the Fremen receives one when they are required to leave the safety of the sietches. There is no noticeable difference between man or woman, leader or follower, and the user does very little to “use” the suit, it operates the same for whoever is wearing it. The primary method of using the suit is by drinking the reclaimed water through a small tube in the mouthpiece, something which anyone can do and everyone has access to. In regards to the flipside of the equipment—the deathstill—its primary purpose is to extract water from the dead. In the case of enemies, such as the Harkonnen, the water can be considered “tainted”, only useful for cooling systems and other technical uses. When the water comes from a member of the Fremen, the water is carried with great reverence in a holy ceremony to a great pool of water, stored deep within the sietch. It is there that it is added to the pool, which contains the water of hundreds of thousands of other Fremen. This provides a strong foundation for the socio/cultural meanings associated with the deathstill and the water reclamation, which will be discussed later. The primary way these deathstills are interfaced is by a series of control mechanisms barely shown in the movie, only

that a team of skilled Fremen are tasked with preparing the body for water extraction. The largest constraint to both of these artifacts is the necessity for the supporting infrastructure. The stillsuits need to be fabricated and maintained, including teaching new Fremen how to wear it, something Paul (the main character) seems to have an intuitive understanding of, which surprises many Fremen in the first movie. The deathstills are specifically incorporated into the sietch infrastructure, unable to be easily moved and only able to be used by skilled technicians. They both provide the Fremen with a valuable ability—retaining and reclaiming water.

It is clear from the movie and the books that this technology is a crucial part in how the Fremen live on Arrakis. In the books, the technology housed within the stillsuits and the deathstills are fabricated in sietches by skilled craftsmen. Almost nothing is shown in *Dune 2* about the production, repair, or disposal of the stillsuits and deathstills. There is also no explanation of the organizational control about the artifacts—it is explained that each sietch has a leader, called a Naib. In *Dune 2*, Stilgar is the Naib in Paul's sietch. It could be argued that the Naib is in charge of ensuring their people have access to the suits, but it is not shown in the movie.

Finally, the most important part of the stillsuits and the deathstill is the cultural and social implications of the technology. The Fremen put an immense amount of religious significance on a member's water. "Water is sacred," a quote told by many throughout the movie, namely Stilgar. There is a pivotal scene in the movie where Stilgar is explaining the rituals to Paul's mother, Lady Jessica, while the Fremen pour Jamis' water into the vast quantity of water held underground in the sietch. Stilgar explained that even if they were dying of thirst, no Fremen would ever take so much as a sip of the water, because it contains the souls of all the Fremen before them, and that they are saving the water for when the planet needs to be restored to a lush ecosystem. Upon realizing the hundreds of thousands of lives required to fill the pool of water, Lady Jessica begins to shed a tear, only for it to be caught by Stilgar, who wipes it with his thumb and drinks it, telling her "Never give your water away, not even for the dead."

This line alone, within the scene about the reverence the Fremen have for the water of the dead, provides a unique and deep insight of how the Fremen exist around this resource. This proved some ethical context around their actions, such as only using the water of enemies for cooling systems, i.e. not allowing them to pass into the “afterlife” of the Fremen. In some cases (primarily in the books and in the unique case of Baron Vladimir Harkonnen), the highest dishonor one can do is leave someone’s body for the desert creatures, water unextracted. It provides the framework to understand the religious and cultural messages the Fremen have within their sietches. I would love to dive into this topic and explain how the “water of life” is a crucial part of their religion (in addition to the social structure around spitting to greet someone), but that is slightly outside the scope of this essay, which is focusing primarily on the stillsuits and deathstills, both of which are the primary ways the Fremen obtain and hold on to water.

Finally, the stillsuits and deathstills provide a unique view into the hyper efficiency of the Fremen culture. Throughout the entire movie, the consistent theme around saving water is being as efficient as possible, whether it be the creation, gathering, or reclaiming of water through various means. This efficiency seeps into the entire Fremen culture, and it is clear that no one is above saving water—be it reverend mothers, Fremen warriors, or children of the sietches. Throughout this essay, a multitude of examples have been given about how the Fremen interact with water, but the stillsuits and deathstills provide a unique perspective to their water-focused efficiencies.

In conclusion, stillsuits and deathstills are a unique technological innovation made by the Fremen initially to combat the harsh realities of living on a desert planet like Arrakis. These complex technologies evolved over time to create social and cultural meanings past their material nature, and have become an integral part of every Fremen life, being worn every day and being the machine that is used at the end of their life to ferry them into the afterlife. While a further analysis on the role of water within the Fremen culture could be done, I believe that stillsuits and deathstills are a key part of this water-scarce social ecosystem.